two women officers, Colonel Sofiya Qureshi and Wg Cdr Vyomika Singh, to brief the media on Operation Sindoor. 'What's in a name?' is not a question anyone had to ask.

AN IMPUGNED FIR

If that evoked a sense of healing amidst a crisis, a most jarring note soon tore the sutures. On May 11, state tribal welfare minister Kunwar Vijay Shah took the mic near Mhow, and spoke filthily about Col. Qureshi. The speech, which expectedly went viral, was profane enough for the MP High Court to sit up and take suo motu notice. 'Guttural,' said Justices Atul Shreedharan and Aradhna Shukla on May 14, bypassing the state's dilatory feints, and ordering its DGP to file a case under stringent sections the same day—or invite contempt.

With no wiggle room, the FIR was duly lodged, but the bench rejected its safe, anodyne phrasing. As the case escalated up the legal ladder, the Supreme Court echoed that tone of high indignation. "The entire nation is shamed," it said on May 19, waving away Shah's 'apology' and ordering an SIT to probe the FIR itself!

It was no rare lapse for Shah. He's a habitual offender when it comes to abasing women. In 2013, he was temporarily sacked after a comment on then CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan's wife. Why does the BJP tolerate him? Context is useful here. Shah, an eight-term MLA, is a scion of the erstwhile feudals of Makdai, who were Gonds. That confers on him both local clout as well as Scheduled Tribe status.

Serious political capital, in short. Especially within the BJP, which is not necessarily the first love of MP's tribals. That shows in how he has been cabinet minister continually since 2003, barring the brief Congress interregnum in 2018-20. The BJP dare not touch a 'senior tribal leader', and Shah uses this leverage to bully the party into accepting his behaviour. This time, he's truly testing the limits of his power. He did nervously tap state BJP chief V.D. Sharma as his words went viral, and his apology ensued. But when the HC sought an FIR under sections that could even send Shah to prison for life, Sharma conferred with CM Mohan Yadav and asked Shah to resign. Insiders say Shah refused point blank.

The BJP soon dug in its heels, mounting a counter-offensive against other parties that had leaders continue in office despite FIRs. "We will do as the court instructs," Yadav said. That protocol is being kept. The SIT was set up on May 19. Till May 21, Shah had neither been sacked nor arrested. Even if that point is reached, Shah has abundantly made clear his political—and nuisance—value. ■

ANI



Takeaways

- **MP tribal welfare minister speaks filthily about Col. Sofiya Qureshi. Video viral**
- **MP High Court takes suo motu notice, orders DGP to file FIR under tough clauses**
- **State police, forced to act, files a light FIR. HC rejects it. Case goes to Supreme Court**
- **SC echoes HC's outrage, says speech "shamed the nation", orders an SIT on FIR**

AFTER TRADING plenty of hot lead and verbal artillery, India and Pakistan's sudden retreat from a near full-blown war has put the spotlight back on a *casus belli* for the future: its six shared rivers. In its ceasefire acceptance, India said the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), put "in abeyance" on April 23, wouldn't be restored. It invokes *rebus sic stantibus*, the principle in international law that allows abrogation of treaties due to a "fundamental change in circumstances".

Jammu and Kashmir, meanwhile, is roiled by a major political divide on how IWT-related projects should move on the ground. J&K is a part of the theatre that bore the brunt of the recent Indo-Pak hostilities, with 22 deaths and damage to over 10,000 buildings. It also hosts the three contentious 'western rivers': Indus, Chenab and Jhelum.

For Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, this is the time he has been awaiting for long. What better than an aerial tour to put the focus on the abandoned Tulbul



NOT ENOUGH The Baglihar dam on the Chenab river at Ramban; inset, Omar and Mehbooba